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Title:

Florida Mae Tuesday's Second 6th Birthday

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Florida Mae Tuesday's Second 6th Birthday

A One-Act Play

Written by Frank Smith

SCENE I

The Tuesday Mansion – Porch.

(A gorgeous home – or it would be, were the lawn ornaments not so…crazy-eyed.)

CAREY, PHIL, TENNESSEE.

(CAREY FULLER (36), permanent case of "God help me" face, stands just outside the door with his son, PHIL FULLER (8), thoughtful, sweet. Carey looks at the bull-shaped knocker like he's entering the gates of hell.)

CAREY. Phil, if you're not having fun, we can just go.

PHIL. Dad, if you're not having fun, we can just go.

CAREY. No, I'm the parent. I have to pretend like I'm enjoying myself even when I'm not.

PHIL. That's true.

CAREY. And hey, one day, you'll be doing it for your son.

PHIL. Or maybe I can take him places we both want to go?

CAREY. What a delusional optimist I'm raising. *(He steels himself before finally knocking at the door.)* How old is Florida Mae turning again?

PHIL. Seven.

CAREY. Oh. I thought the invitation said six.

PHIL. It's her second 6th Birthday.

CAREY. Not to be confused with her first 6th Birthday?

PHIL. No. Remember that baseball game last year, when that kid threw his bat, and it hit her in the face, and she went into a coma, and the kid cried because he felt bad putting her in a coma?

CAREY. Hazily.

PHIL. So she was in a coma on her actual 6th Birthday. And that's why it didn't count.

CAREY. Of course. Via The Law of Unconscious Birthdays. I honestly forgot that she got hurt.

PHIL. Well, I guess it was right around the time that Mom was…sorry.

CAREY. Buddy, you don't have to be sorry.

PHIL. So…wait. We can start talking about her again?

CAREY. We never stopped, it's just…easier sometimes when you don't—

(The front door opens wide to reveal TENNESSEE TUESDAY (32), thick Southern accent for a thick Southern gentleman.)

TENNESSEE. If it isn't Carey and Phil Fuller! Florida Mae can't wait to see the two of you.

CAREY. I mean, my son, obviously, he's outstanding, but…why can't she wait to see me?

TENNESSEE. Why, because she's sweet on you, of course! Why else would she refer to you as "the Silverest of Foxes."

CAREY. Your daughter knows the word, "Silver Fox?"

TENNESSEE. Okay, I *might* have taught it to her, but only because it's what her heart implied! So maybe when you go in, you can say she looks pretty in her red dress, really make her day.

CAREY. I'd be happy to.

TENNESSEE. She may also ask if she can marry you. Just say yes! That'd *really* make her day.

CAREY. I don't know about that, Tennessee.

TENNESSEE. Ah, you'll come around. We'll just have to get you a drink first.

CAREY. That is a disturbing plan of action.

TENNESSEE. All right, enough chatting on the porch, come on in, you two! I assume your present is a gift certificate because I don't see any big bags or animal cages, which is fine! Because cash is king, and I've had to replace too many ferrets this month anyway. *(Gravely.)* Florida Mae has not been very forgiving of all the stealing.

SCENE II

The Tuesday Mansion – Kitchen.

(Even in this room…there's taxidermy. Spaghetti cools in several colanders in the sink.)

TENNESSEE, PHIL, CAREY, FLORIDA MAE.

TENNESSEE. You'll never guess what the theme of the party is. Spaghetti!

PHIL. I love spaghetti!

TENNESSEE. Of course you do. Everyone does! *(Wistful.)* Even the ferrets. Poor things never saw that can opener coming.

CAREY. *(Pulling a gift card out of his coat.)* So here's Florida Mae's present. Sorry if it seems small and not thought-out, it's just, Joy was the one who used to be on top of this kind of thing…

TENNESSEE. Now, don't you worry your pretty little head. You're only here to have yourself a good time – so I don't want to hear any more talk about your beautiful dead wife, you got it?

CAREY. Umm…no problem?

TENNESSEE. Attaboy.

(FLORIDA MAE TUESDAY (7), good-hearted girl whose mania is too young to be diagnosable, races in wearing a Birthday tiara and wielding a Birthday scepter.)

FLORIDA MAE. Well golly me, if it isn't my good pal Phil! *(She gives him a big hug before laying eyes on Carey. She bows to him.)* Sir: I do declare, if I ever drink tea half as sweet as you, I'll have had enough sugar to last me a lifetime. And! You're so…powerful…like a mountain.

TENNESSEE. *(Sotto, to Carey.)* What did I tell you?

CAREY. Happy 7th…I mean, *not* your 6th…Birthday, Florida Mae.

FLORIDA MAE. Thank you, darling! *(Sidling up to him.)* How can I ever repay such kindness?

CAREY. You…and my *son*…can go off and have fun together.

FLORIDA. Aww, and leave you all by your lonesome!?

TENNESSEE. Now now, it's for the best. We do need to get this pasta lunch ready, sweetheart. *(Leading.)* But before you hunker off…I think Carey had something to say about your dress?

CAREY. It's…red.

(Florida Mae SCREAMS with delight. Seriously, she looks happy enough to pass out.)

TENNESSEE. All right girl, calm down, he didn't go back in time and win the war for you.

CAREY. Which war are we talking…?

TENNESSEE. Go on, skedaddle. Mr. Fuller and I are going to have us some adult talk.

FLORIDA MAE. And we'll have us some sweet little baby talk!

(Florida Mae takes Phil by the hand as they leave the kitchen.)

TENNESSEE. Now, Carey, I know I said not to bring down the mood with all that talk about your lovely deceased spouse…

CAREY. Yes. Almost threateningly.

TENNESSEE. But that's because you owe it to yourself to move on. Been over a year now, as I recall? Long time not to be in…the swing of things. Know what I'm saying? Yeah. You do. And that is why…I have rounded up a cadre of genuine, gorgeous females so you can pick a rebound!

CAREY. Tennessee, you really don't have to—

TENNESSEE. Too late. Already did!

CAREY. *(Concerned.)* Please tell me one of them's not your 6-year-old daughter.

TENNESSEE. Quit talking nonsense, boy. Florida Mae is 7!

SCENE III

The Tuesday Mansion – Living Room.

(Kids run around and play in this ode to Southern comfort.)

TROY, FLORIDA MAE, PHIL, RAYNA.

(TROY BOZEMAN (7), chubby red cheeks like a squirrel, intercepts Florida Mae as she takes Phil into the room.)

TROY. Florida Mae, when's lunch? I'm starving!

FLORIDA MAE. Troy Bozeman, I swear, if your appetite were any bigger, it'd be Texas.

TROY. *(Sarcastic.)* Oh, you're from Texas? I had *no* idea!

FLORIDA MAE. Mercy me. Someone's *hangry*.

PHIL. Wait, if you're from Texas, why is your name Florida?

FLORIDA. Oh my goodness, Phil, you can't just ask someone why they're not from Florida! Geez Louise. Anyway, let's talk about *you*. How you been living?

PHIL. Well, I—

FLORIDA MAE. Mmhmm mmhmm. And how's your *Daddy*?

PHIL. He's all right, I guess. Seems to finally be over my Mom.

FLORIDA MAE. Oh reallyyyyyy. Over her, you sayyyyy.

PHIL. I mean, he never really talks about her anymore.

FLORIDA MAE. Well, isn't that good? It's been a year now, right? I measure time by the number of days since I got concussed by that old baseball bat.

TROY. I *said* I was sorry!

FLORIDA MAE. Sweet pea, you should've seen the dent in that bat! Now IT was sorry. *(Darkly.)* Just like the ferrets after they took my artisanal candles. *(Sweetly.)* Besides, your Momma was gettin' *old* when she died. I think your Daddy would fancy himself a younger gal these days, don't you?

PHIL. Maybe. And I'd be okay with that. Just as long as he stops acting like Mom never existed. All her pictures are gone. He gave away all her clothes. He doesn't even talk to my Aunt Cora. Well, that was true before Mom died, too. He says being trapped in a room with just her is like being a victim of the "Salem Bitch Trials." But Mom said he was wrong about her. It was more like being at an "All You Can Bitch Buffet."

(RAYNA LETTS (8), sincere to the point of being painful, walks over to the group, intrigued by this line of conversation.)

RAYNA. Hey, Phil. It's Rayna. From third grade. While I've never had a parent die, exactly, one time, my Mom did say I was an "accident. But a good one. Like when you get rear-ended and they pay for it. Actually, it was exactly like that."

PHIL. Thanks, Rayna. That's…kind of on-topic?

RAYNA. Kind of I think!

TROY. When are we having spaghetti already!? I'm seeing mirages, but with red sauce.

FLORIDA MAE. Troy, do you ever talk about anything but food?

PHIL. Why would he? He loves it. *(Realizing.)* Do you think that's why my Dad doesn't talk about my Mom anymore? He stopped loving her once she died?

FLORIDA. Yay hooray for me! Aww, but sad for you. But yay hooray for me!

TROY. Now I'm *sangry*. Sad, and hungry.

PHIL. I hope I'm wrong. And he does still love her.

FLORIDA MAE. *(Sarcastic.)* Why…because she isn't dead yet!?

PHIL. *(Sincerely.)* I don't know. Maybe.

RAYNA. But if she isn't dead, then what would she be…undead?

PHIL. *(Won over.)* Exactly!

FLORIDA MAE. Crap. Now if I want to be your Daddy's sweetheart, I gotta go stab a *zombie* through the head? Guess I better find that can opener again.

SCENE IV
The Tuesday Mansion – Kitchen.
TENNESSEE, CAREY, RHONDA, BEVERLY.

TENNESSEE. Now let me introduce you to your first eligible bachelorette.

CAREY. Look, you don't have to do this, single and sad is actually a pretty good look on me—

TENNESSEE. Rhonda, this is the guy I told you about. With the gorgeous six feet under spouse? You two mingle. I'm gonna put the meatballs in the spaghetti.

CAREY. Is there a vegetarian or vegan option?

TENNESSEE. What are those two hate-words you just said?

(RHONDA SIMMS (36), too calm to not be insane, puts her hand out for Phil to shake.)

RHONDA. Tennessee, leave us alone already! Hi there! It's Rhonda. My husband's gone too.

CAREY. Carey. And I'm sorry to hear that.

TENNESSEE. Oh, not gone gone, like your stunning sleeping with the fishes lover.

RHONDA. Tennessee! Let the magic happen. *(He goes.)* He's right, though. I am divorced.

CAREY. Oh, well, I'm still sorry.

RHONDA. Honestly? So am I. In divorce, you only get half the assets. But if he dies, you get all of them!

CAREY. That is…true, from personal experience.

RHONDA. Oh sorry, that's so insensitive of me. It's just, you know, lawyers…ugh. He was in great health, though, my ex. He would never have just…died. I would have had to kill him.

CAREY. Oh, umm, that sounds, dangerous. For both of you.

RHONDA. Not really. He liked to fall asleep with cigarettes in his mouth. I could've burned the house to cinders and gotten away with it.

CAREY. You…never would have done that, though.

RHONDA. No. I loved that house.

CAREY. But…also, because you have children. Right?

RHONDA. Well, *obviously* I would have made sure the kids were out of the house when I did it. Hired a babysitter, given them an alibi. And even on the off-chance I actually *did* get caught, if I had to do it all over again? I would still choose murder over divorce. The trial is much shorter.

CAREY. *(Concerned.)* Tennessee. Tennessee!? Need me to cook meat or something? Please!?

TENNESSEE. *(He comes back over.)* All right, scoot, Rhonda, clearly, Mr. Fuller ain't buying what you're giving away on clearance.

(Rhonda walks away. Another woman walks up to Carey: BEVERLY GORK (32), fighting through her sad to be strong and caring.)

BEVERLY. Hello. I'm Beverly.

CAREY. Carey.

TENNESSEE. Now you and Bev actually have a lot in common. She also has a fit dead as a doornail, deader than disco, deadest possible dead-iddy-dead-dead life partner. *(He goes again.)*

CAREY. I'm so sorry…that you had to hear that. And that your husband is gone.

BEVERLY. Thank you. It was so sudden.

CAREY. Same here.

BEVERLY. It's been almost a year, but…I don't know. Some days I'm still surprised that he doesn't sit down with me for dinner. He hated my cooking, but never left a bite on his plate. That's love. Or masochism. Maybe both.

CAREY. I totally know what you mean. I see Joy, in crowds, sometimes. I thought that was just a thing people said to get onto a reality show for psychics, but it's true.

BEVERLY. You know, for me, what's hardest is my little girl. I never know what the right amount to talk about her Dad is.

CAREY. *(Touched.)* Wow. Uh, yeah. Me neither.

TENNESSEE. *(He returns.)* Okay, WOW, is this depressing, or what? What's worse than two grieving widows in the same room? Literally nothing! Truthfully, I think I've had bowel movements that were more exciting than this. Some *really* exciting ones, actually. Suspenseful, even. Okay, Bev, you move it along now, I've got more single ladies to show Mr. Fuller.

CAREY. No, Tennessee, I don't want to meet more women…

TENNESSEE. Why, boy? You'd rather meet men?

CAREY. No?

TENNESSEE. Good. Since I don't know many queers. But I'm open to meeting some! *(Clarifying.)* For you.

SCENE V
The Tuesday Mansion – Living Room.
PHIL, TROY, FLORIDA MAE, RAYNA.

PHIL. What do undead Moms eat, anyway? Brains, same as everyone else?

TROY. Gross! No, I should be more open-minded. I've never tried brains. Just goat liver.

FLORIDA MAE. *(Viciously.)* Ferret's better.

PHIL. If I want to keep my Mom alive…I need to keep feeding her brains.

RAYNA. Phil, I may have never had a dead zombie Mom before, but one time, my Dad didn't get much sleep, and was very grouchy with me. He said he regretted "having me with my Mom, and even more than that, doing the right thing by staying."

PHIL. Although, what is the right thing in this case? Keeping my Mom alive? Or protecting her future victims from her? There's a lot of moral relativism at play here.

FLORIDA MAE. Maybe your Momma's not undead after all. Maybe she's just one of them there immortals. Oh phooey. Now I *really* won't stand a chance with your Daddy! *(Realizing.)* Uh-oh. Quick question. Can certain animals be undead too? Like, I don't knowwwww, for the sake of a *completely* random example…somewhere between three to five ferrets?

PHIL. Probably? I'd sleep with a weapon. *(Determined.)* But you guys. I think I need to go find my undead Mom some brains to eat.

FLORIDA MAE. Not mine. Take Troy's! He barely uses his. He's more of a…gut kind of man.

TROY. I trust my instincts. And my instincts say… *(Scared.)* please don't feed me to your Mom!

PHIL. I won't! I promise. No pinky, though. Look, the undead aren't always the smartest, right? So maybe I can just feed her something that *looks* like brains.

RAYNA. Do you know what brains look like? I've only ever seen an exposed kneecap, when my Dad shot out my Mom's, saying, "This is literally what you do to me metaphorically."

FLORIDA MAE. Rayna, your family's nuttier than a pecan pie made by squirrels!

RAYNA. That's what grandma said! Before she got shot too. By the mailman. Who looked an awful lot like me, now that I'm thinking about it.

TROY. Is it weird that all this talk of senseless violence is making me *famished*?

PHIL. Just imagine being my Mom – she hasn't eaten in a year!

FLORIDA MAE. It's called a diet, boy, all us females have to try it out at some point. Let's go!

SCENE VI

The Tuesday Mansion – Kitchen.

TENNESSEE, CAREY, SADIE ELLEN, PHIL, FLORIDA MAE, TROY, RAYNA,BEVERLY.

TENNESSEE. Fine! One more dame, then you can commit to a lifetime of loneliness and pills.

CAREY. Thank you.

(SADIE ELLEN (29), sweet but still mischievous, joins the pair.)

TENNESSEE. Now, this one, I'm surprised you haven't met yet, because she's definitely my favorite. Here's good ol' Sadie Ellen. Sadie, Mr. Fuller is the guy I mentioned earlier, you know, the one with the total-knockout worm-food ride-or-die?

SADIE ELLEN. Oh, I remember.

CAREY. He makes it impossible to forget.

SADIE ELLEN. Salutations, gorgeous.

CAREY. *(Realizing.)* Wait, Tennessee…this isn't…hold on a sec…is Sadie Ellen your wife!?

TENNESSEE. Sure is!

SADIE ELLEN. We have one of those, what do you call them… "open relationships." And I don't want you to think that this is just a pity date because you're a widower. I genuinely…*want* you. Grief is just a fine, fine look on some men. And you're one of them, Mr. Sad-Sexy-Eyes.

CAREY. Yikes. Tennessee, is this really better than being single forever?

TENNESSEE. She was for me!

CAREY. Okay, enough. I have entertained this…borderline-predatory match game for way too long. I think I'm just going to grab Phil and leave.

TENNESSEE. Oh, so because *you're* having a bad time, your son has to suffer along with you?

CAREY. Uh, what does that mean?

TENNESSEE. It means…Carey. I know you a bit better than you might think. You used to be real fun, and spontaneous…maybe even a little "suggestive." Now, you just come to things, and go from things. You make no effort to mingle, or get to know anyone. But you're still…*here*. And you need to act like it.

CAREY. Tennessee, what are you implying, exactly?

TENNESSEE. I'm stating outright…that the way you are is starting to affect your family. We've all seen it. You hold on a little too tight, are a little too careful with the things you say.

BEVERLY. *(Pokes her head in.)* And I know the feeling. Since Harry died, I always feel like I'm walking on eggshells around my…

TENNESSEE. Oh my LORD, Beverly, you could bring down the mood at a candlelight vigil! Would you give me and Mr. Fuller a minute already!?

CAREY. Go easy on her, Tennessee, we're both still grieving.

TENNESSEE. Carey. You think I haven't suffered loss, or very nearly close to it? You know what I did, after Florida Mae hit her head last year? Sent her right back onto the baseball field. Not literally right after, I waited till she was out of the wheelchair, but…and you know why I did that!? Because when you fall off the horse…only solution is to get right back on. And unlike most people who use that phrase, I've actually ridden horses – even lady-ones! So I surely know what I'm talking about.

CAREY. But Florida Mae survived. Plus, *you* were the one telling me not to talk about Joy!

TENNESSEE. At parties, Carey. There's a time and place for everything. And here, at this party, it's about letting your son forget about his sad Dad, and his dead Mom, just for a minute…and helping him have *fun*.

(On cue, Phil, Florida Mae, Troy, and Rayna race into the kitchen, hunting for spaghetti.)

PHIL. Out of the way, out of the way! I've got to get brain-food for my Mom-bie!!!

CAREY. What?

FLORIDA MAE. *(To Carey.)* Grab all the pasta you can now, sweet thing! The more red sauce, the better. Wouldn't want your old lady to get in the way of your *new* one!

TROY. Can I have some of the leftovers?

(The kids throw all the spaghetti they find into a pile on the floor.)

TENNESSEE. Now what in the perfect paradise is going on around here!?

FLORIDA MAE. *(Rapid-fire.)* Phil's Mom is one of the walking dead and we need to feed her spaghetti because it looks like brains and oh my goodness me why aren't you helping out yet!?

CAREY. Excuse me. Hold on a second. You think my wife is undead?

RAYNA. Mr. Fuller, I've never had an undead bride before, but I did marry my Teddy Bear after we both had had too much tea, and he doesn't talk to me anymore, so it's *like* he's a zombie. Also, I'm pretty sure my Mom put a camera in him. That's okay. It's nice to be watched sometimes. It means people care about you!

FLORIDA MAE. Rayna, girl, you gotta get a legal emancipation, like, *yesterday*, but for now: focus on the task at hand!

RAYNA. *(Grabbing a jar off the counter.)* Okay, I found sauce! Oh, boo. It's Alfredo.

TROY. Ooh, let me have some!

(Rayna pours some sauce into Troy's mouth.)

TROY. *(Mouth full.)* You're a queen. Keep it going.

(Rayna pours more sauce into Troy's mouth before dumping the rest on the floor.)

TENNESSEE. Can someone just explain to me, slowly, what is happening right here right now?

PHIL. We think my Mom's a zombie.

TENNESSEE. Aww, that's adorable.

PHIL. No, it's deadly! I saw how my Dad wasn't talking about my Mom. But it's not because he doesn't care about her. It's because she's still alive, in…some shape or form. Right, Dad?

CAREY. Buddy…buddy, no.

PHIL. So you *wouldn't* rather have a flesh-eating wife than no wife at all?

TENNESSEE. Well, a little nibble never hurt nobody, but—

CAREY. Phil. I don't talk about your Mom because…I don't want to reopen an old wound.

PHIL. Mom isn't a wound, Dad. Even if her skin is mostly lesions now.

CAREY. It's really not. Your Mom may not be here with us, but trust me, I won't forget her. I just don't like to make you, and me, sadder than we already are by bringing her up all the time.

PHIL. But I'm sadder when you don't say anything at all. I like remembering Mom. She was great. *(Sadly.)* We loved her.

CAREY. *(Tearing up.)* Yeah. We do, buddy.

FLORIDA MAE. Well, it's plain to see there is no hope for me with you anymore. Now I'm sad. Ooh, I know! Rayna, come with me, let's go hunting in the backyard for ferrets.

TROY. I'm almost hungry enough to eat one!

FLORIDA MAE. Heyyyyy, now that could be real fun for me to watch!

RAYNA. I actually have had a dead pet before. Well, not so much a pet, as a baby sister, but—

(Florida Mae, Troy, and Rayna leave the kitchen, as Beverly slides in.)

CAREY. You know what, Phil? I don't know if this would be interesting to you at all, but I actually did keep a handful of photos of Mom, just in case I regretted getting rid of the rest of them. Would you want to maybe…put those up with me when we get home?

PHIL. Yeah. Yeah, Dad. I really would.

SADIE ELLEN. I am getting so damn emotional over here! *(Seductively.)* Tennessee. You want to head upstairs and…do something with that?

TENNESSEE. Carey – last call! No? Okay, just us. Have fun reminiscing about your perfect 10 *(Pantomimes a graphic death.)* soulmate! *(Tennessee and Sadie Ellen holding hands / butts.)*

CAREY. Phil, you want to say goodbye to your friends, so we can take off?

PHIL. Sure, Dad. Hey, listen…I'm really glad you're still alive. But even if you were un-alive, I would totally come and feed you, no matter how many innocent lives it cost. *(He runs off.)*

CAREY. Back at you, buddy.

BEVERLY. Carey. I'm about to head out too, but I just wanted you to know – I'm really glad I got to meet you today. It's nice to finally talk to someone who knows what you're going through. Not that being a widow 100% defines my whole personality, but I guess today, it kind of did!

CAREY. Same!

BEVERLY. Seriously, though: Joy sounds…great.

CAREY. She was. Maybe sometime we can get a coffee and…I can tell you more about her? And you can tell me a little bit more about Harry?

BEVERLY. I'd love that.

CAREY. Well then, I guess we proved the old adage true: misery loves company.

TENNESSEE. *(From upstairs.)* That's the spirit!

SADIE ELLEN. *(From upstairs.)* Loss is nature's aphrodisiac.

CAREY. Wow. Those two are crazy in love. Moreso crazy than in love.

BEVERLY. I'm looking forward to going crazy again someday.

CARL. Me too.

TENNESSE. *(From upstairs.)* But don't go moving too fast, Carey!

SADIE ELLEN. *(From upstairs.)* Yeah, you know, just because her husband died, doesn't mean she's a good person!

CAREY. *(Shouting upstairs.)* Goodbye, Tennessee! Thanks for everything.

BEVERLY. *(Shouting upstairs.)* Great party, minus all the weird parts!

CAREY. Yeah. It really was. Weird. *(Sincerely, to himself.)* Welp. Happy Second 6th Birthday, Florida Mae.

THE END.